

Feature-packed Google TV media streamer

Media streamers based on the Google TV platform have been announced by several consumer electronics makers including ASUS, Logitech and Hisense. The ASUS Qube is one such Google TV-based entertainment device with some special features like a microphone for voice search and a unique main menu interface. It is a compact, cube-shaped device measuring less than 12.7 cm (5 inches) along the edge, and includes ample ports, support for all common formats, several useful apps, wired and wireless connectivity, and a feature-packed remote.

Inside: The Qube uses a Marvell Armada 1500 chipset and comes with 4 GB of Flash storage. It can connect to the Internet using the 10/100 Ethernet port or wirelessly using 802.11b/g/n. There are two HDMI ports, so you can also plug in your cable or satellite TV set-top box. There are two USB ports, which you can use to connect to an external hard drive or Flash drive. There is also a port for the IR emitter, in case you wish to control your TV or AV receiver via IR using the Qube's remote. The device comes with HDMI-CEC, which enables the TV and receiver to automatically turn on or turn off when the Qube does. The remote has a track pad, which you can use as a pointing device or as a push-button d-pad for standard up-down-right-left navigation. It also includes a microphone and buttons to activate voice search.

The Qube's main menu features a special design—a three-dimensional hexahedron with only two sides exposed. The left side is used to indicate which of the main sections is currently selected, while the right offers sub-menus to drill into. Apart from typical Google apps, the Qube also includes other applications like HBO Go, Netflix, Chrome, Google Play, Google Music, PrimeTime, Whiteboard (to turn your TV into a collaboration device) and ASUS Web Storage to easily access your content on the Cloud. ASUS also offers apps for accessing your movies, music and photos via DLNA, FTP, SMB or an external USB-attached hard drive. Almost all typical formats, codecs and containers are supported.



Listen to music the traditional way

It does seem very convenient to store all our audio files in compressed formats like MP3, but sometimes when we play an archived or downloaded music file, or stream Internet radio on a high-end audio system, we wish we had the original disks. With this new, innovative personal audio converter, things might be much better. Arcam has launched rPAC—a portable digital-to-analogue converter (DAC) that has won a lot of critical acclaim. It brings high-end hi-fi quality to the audio files on your laptop or desktop, by bypassing the internal amplifier in your device, and processing and amplifying the audio by itself.

Inside: rPAC is a compact, 300gm, box-shaped device that can easily sit in a pocket. It features hi-fi-grade hardware and software engineering, designed to enhance all audio—be it low-bitrate Internet radio, CD-quality or even higher. The USB-powered plug-and-play device supports 24-bit depth, sample rates of 96 kHz and frequency response of 10 kHz to 20 kHz. Its built-in amplifiers provide a high headphone output power of 138 mW. It can output to audio systems using a standard RCA lead or to headphones using the 3.5mm jack. It also features independent volume controls.

Asynchronous USB technology removes jitter by using its own precision clock circuits to control timing inside the DAC. Radio frequency suppression eliminates background noise due to high-frequency radio bands within the computer. rPAC uses a TI Burr-Brown PCM5102 DAC chipset, and supports Windows XP, Windows 7 and Mac OS X (Linux is not supported yet).

